

Dear Jen,

There is a real mystery to this city. It seems as if the evil just crawls beneath the surface of society. On the surface, everyone we meet seems happy that we are here and preaches about how horrible Saddam Hussein was, yet there is something else going on. It was well suppressed immediately following the war, but is slowly starting to stir again. There are no major incidents during the day, but slowly, the evil is coming to the surface at night. In the last few days we have had our hands full. We spend the days searching for schools and police stations and hospitals, and we do our best to get them up and operational again. In addition, we are working hard to set up an interim Iraqi government at the local level so that the people can begin to govern themselves. Everyone seems happy and helpful, most of the time. At night it is a completely different story. I don't know if its because there are different groups of people circulating at night that hide out during the day, or if the shiny-happy-people of the daytime transform from Dr. Jekyll to Mr. Hyde.

In the past week, the US has had a soldier shot in the knee and another killed. The first was investigating an intelligence lead, and I am unaware of the circumstances surrounding the second incident. Our new zone has been no picnic either. In the past few nights, we have had a drive-by shooting at one of our command posts; we have had shots fired at our complex here; and we have witnessed numerous small arms (AK-47s and Machine Guns) battles between local factions. It has been a drastic change from the peaceful SCANIA complex that we abandoned. The events range from the dangerous to the downright ridiculous. Yesterday, we received a report of an individual threatening to blow up local businesses. When we went to investigate, we found the man tied to a tree by the local business owners—and he did in fact have grenades on him. The nights have been far from quiet. Our traffic control points stop vehicles on a regular basis in which people are armed with assault rifles, pistols, and even grenades. Our TOC has been somewhat disorganized since we moved as we struggle to put all the pieces in place. This has been most obvious in our EPW escort operations at night. We have resorted to waking up drivers and guards for the EPW truck in the middle of the night and sending them on missions. Needless to say this has been a painful process with lots of bickering and in-fighting. At least this part of the operation seems to be settling down as we put process and duty rosters in place again.

Our Charlie Company, however, received news today that they will begin redeployment this week. This sent a ripple of excitement throughout the Battalion as hopes of going home danced in our heads. These hopes we short lived. We soon found out that only one company will be headed home while the rest of us are left to slug out several more months here with the 1st Armor Division. We are doing our best to make this military complex our new home. We expect to be here a while. I used a permanent marker to write "The LT. Lair" on the wall of our dusty room, and we have begun to hang our pictures over our newly acquired cots. The simple rusty bucket we have used for a latrine for the last month has been replaced by wooden outhouse structures which at least dress

the toilet facilities up a little. To reduce the effects of the stagnant daytime heat, we have put up a fan in our TOC that at least creates a little breeze. In addition we are growing immune to the drone of the loudspeakers sitting on top of the mosk located just outside our compound walls. At least three times daily, beginning at four in the morning, the mosk transmits prayer chants across the city—forcefully delivering religion to the residents of Baghdad. At least this is what we think they are doing, but its hard to tell since we really don't understand a word. Yes, everyone is adapting except for Major Wick. He decided when we first moved into the military facility that he would put his office right next to the TOC. This is probably a good idea, except for the fact that he also sleeps in his office. For some reason he hears every little pin drop, and this makes it difficult for us at night. He comes in at least 3 times every night complaining about the volume of our radios or that we are talking too loudly and insists that we keep the noise down. The way I see it, this is the Battalion's place of business—the command center, and we should be able to operate at a reasonable volume both day and night since it is required. I don't understand why he doesn't just move his bedroom into the other building where everyone else sleeps.

Lt. Sproesser and I have assumed much larger roles in the TOC this week. We now basically serve as battle captains and are left to manage the entire operation. The Captains, who formerly ran the TOC, sit back and read magazines or write letters, and are ready to assist in case we need them. This is actually a welcome change since I thought that I would go crazy simply monitoring the radio for months on end. At least this way I feel like I am contributing and performing a significant function. I think we do pretty well.

Otherwise life goes on in this place. This place where evil seems to be lurking just beneath the surface. The apparent peace in the daytime gives way to relative instability at night, and we continue to work to restore normal life. I don't really care for Iraq, and if I could come home today, I don't think that I would care what happened to this place, but that is not my call. Well, I can't wait to get this over with—be it June, July, or next January. I think about you and Mason everyday and hope that things are going well. We will have access to phones from the 13th to the 17th, and I will call you then.

Love,

A handwritten signature in cursive script, appearing to read "Christian".

Christian